

Post-incident review PIR-2025-011

Order Management: delayed processing

Contoso Platform Engineering. Fictional sample data.

Summary

On 04 July 2025, Order Management experienced delayed processing in production (AU East) for about 40 minutes. A developer in another team noticed their integration tests failing against the service. Investigation found that the autoscaler reached its maximum instance count during a traffic peak.

Impact

Users of Order Management saw delayed processing for about 40 minutes. The service owner, Commerce Platform, led the response.

Timeline

- 09:06 First signal received.
- 09:32 Incident declared and on-call team engaged.
- 09:45 Likely cause identified.
- 10:20 Mitigation applied.
- 10:55 Service confirmed healthy and incident closed.

What happened

Investigation found that the autoscaler reached its maximum instance count during a traffic peak.

No dependency outages were reported by upstream providers during the window.

The expected load had not been tested before release.

It took time to work out which team owned the affected component.

The change was made outside the approved maintenance window.

What went well

Responders communicated clearly in the incident channel and the status page was updated within fifteen minutes of the incident being declared.

Actions

- Write and rehearse a runbook for this failure mode.
- Add a synthetic probe that exercises the affected path every minute.
- Review alert thresholds so the alert only fires when action is needed.